because of a mounting economic crisis in the Ming empire, a large number defected to join the Jurchen.

The Ming dynasty came to an end with a series of peasant revolts. The peasant leader Li Zecheng captured the capital city of Beijing in 1644 but was defeated by a combined army of the Ming General Wu Sangui, who had shifted his allegiance to the Jurchen, and the Manchu prince Dorgon, in June of that year. However, it took several years before the rest of the country was pacified. The Qing dynasty armies that carried out these pacification campaigns were a mixed force of Manchu, Han and Mongol soldiers, all serving the Manchu overlord.

The Jianzhou Jurchen, who later took on the name Manchu, united together under the Aisin Gioro clan, whose key figure was Nurhaci (reigned between 1616 and 1626). Nurhaci united most of the tribes in the north-east, thereby establishing a substantial kingdom in Manchuria. It was under the reign of his son Hong Taiji that the Jurchen began to throw off their tributary status and looked to conquering China itself from a declining Ming dynasty. Hong Taiji's Han Chinese advisers were believed to have encouraged him to declare himself the emperor of China and establish a new dynasty. In May 1636, an elaborate Confucian ritual was held crowning him as the emperor. The dynasty name of Qing was derived from the historical links with the Jurchen Jin who had ruled northern China in the twelfth and thirteenth centuries. It was with the defeat of the peasant army of Li Zecheng in 1644 that the Qing dynasty was formally established. In the meantime, Hong Taiji had died and his six-year-old son was enthroned as the emperor, with the Manchu prince Dorgon serving as a powerful regent until his death in 1650.

The Qing empire was expanded and consolidated under a series of powerful and able leaders, among them Kangxi (1661–1722), Yongzheng (1722–35) and Qianlong (1735–96). The empire reached its maximum extent under the reign of Qianlong. The Qing empire was a multi-ethnic entity and was presented as a common space occupied by the five races of Manchu, Han, Mongol, Tibetan and Uighur. While the Han were numerically the largest, the Qing emperors sought to give all five races